book.

My Army service number was 43012053, and that night we were put on a train and taken to Fort Meade, near Baltimore, Maryland. We went through Wilmington, which I had once visited in order to see Irene over five years before, and then passed on farther South—farther South than I had ever been in my life.

It was a peculiar feeling. For the first time in my life, I was going somewhere without my parents, without my wife, and without my volition. I kept watching the telephone poles slide backward outside the window and I kept saying to myself, "I can't change my mind. I can't get off the train. I can't go back home. I've got to go wherever I'm told. I have no say in the matter."

I was in prison, in a way.

We didn't go to bed till midnight that night, and by that time each of us was given a barracks bag for our belongings, and a fatigue

1 Otitis, or inflammation of the ear canal, had been plaguing me throughout the Philadelphia years.

uniform to wear. Since we were given the fatigues at random, they weren't expected to fit, and mine were far too large.

We were awakened at 4:30 a.m. on November 2. At least some of the soldiers were awakened. I hadn't slept. When a corporal came roaring into the barracks shouting, "Rise and shine! Hubba hubba! Up 'n' at 'em!" and all the other horrible sounds I despised from the start, I waited for him to pass and then I said calmly, "Corporal, what time is it?"

I instantly learned the measure of manliness in the Army: It was how far you could recede from ordinary decency.

The corporal said, "How the hell should I know?"

Whereupon I said, "But if you don't know what time it is, how do you know it's time to wake us?"

The corporal stopped short. He was keen enough to recognize, at once, the prime enemy of any military individual—the rational mind. He said, tightly, "What's your name and serial number, private?"